

The Lost **TREASURE**

Ubi Fredrick



The Lost Treasure. By Ubi Fredrick

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Dedication



To those who have stood over “empty ground” and wept for a treasure lost; To the memory of the lights that faded too soon, leaving the young heart to navigate the dark; And to every resilient soul still “sweeping their square”, waiting for the shadows to turn to sunshine— This book is for you. May you find that the truest treasure was never buried in the earth, but born within the struggle.

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Foreword



Every story has a heartbeat, a rhythmic pulse that begins long before the first word is ever committed to paper. For *The Lost Treasure*, that heartbeat was born from a simple yet profound series of images: a child, a gift of money, a hole in the earth, and the crushing silence of an empty harvest.

We often think of treasure as something tangible—gold coins, paper notes, or vast inheritances hidden in legal briefcases. But through the journey of Giovanni, I wanted to explore a different kind of wealth. This book is a meditation on the "Earth School," the place where life strips us of our material safety to see what we are truly made of when the shadows fall.

The inspiration for this narrative came from the universal experience of loss and the naive hope we all carry. We have all, at some point, "planted" something—a dream, a relationship, or a hard-earned resource—only to find the earth empty when we went back to dig. In those moments of disappointment, we face a choice: do we perish in the dirt, or do we realize, as Giovanni did, that the true seed was never the paper we buried, but the mind that conceived the dream?

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Writing this book was a journey of resilience for me as much as it was for the characters. It is a story dedicated to the "displaced"—to those who have lost their homes, their parents, or their sense of self to the "Aishas" of the world. It is a reminder that while people can steal your inheritance and the earth can rot your money; no one can touch the treasure of a resilient will.

As you flip through these pages, I invite you to look past the red dust of Apar and the busy streets of LoPON. Look instead into the spirit of a young boy who refused to stay in the shadows. May his story inspire you to sweep your own "village square" and write your own future in the dust, until the world has no choice but to give you a pen.

— Ubi Fredrick, Author

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Preface



The architecture of *The Lost Treasure* did not begin with a plot or a character; it began with a visual sequence. This book is the result of a creative experiment—an attempt to expand five distinct, silent images into a sprawling narrative of human resilience.

As an author, I have always been fascinated by the power of silent storytelling. The seeds of this book were sown by five specific snapshots:

- The Gift: A child receiving a note of money, his face glowing with a rare, pure joy.
- The Planting: That same child, driven by a naive faith, burying his treasure in a field.
- The Nurturing: The daily ritual of watering the earth, waiting for a miracle.
- The Doubt: The frantic digging when the "miracle" fails to break the surface.
- The Void: A child crying over an empty hole—a mystery of loss that the world never explains.

My goal in writing this book was to build a world around those images. I wanted to know who that boy was, what

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he had lost before he ever found that money, and what kind of man he would have to become to survive the disappointment of that empty hole.

To bridge these images, I drew upon my observations of life in both the bustling urban centers and the quiet, traditional villages of Nigeria. I wanted to capture the contrast between the "city greed" represented by Aisha and the "earth wisdom" represented by characters like Mr. Bola.

This book is a journey through the "Earth School." It is a technical exploration of how suspense can be used to mirror the uncertainties of life. Whether the money was stolen by a neighbor or reclaimed by the soil is a question I leave for the reader to ponder—because in life, as in this story, the "how" of our losses is often less important than "who" we become in the aftermath.

— Ubi Fredrick

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Prelude



In the village of Apar, time is not measured by the ticking of a clock, but by the lengthening of shadows against the red earth.

Before the storms came, before the sea claimed its due, and before the ground became a grave for a young boy's hope, there was a season of perfect light. It was a time when the laughter of Miriam rang louder than the haggling of the marketplace, and the broad shoulders of Ma'mud acted as a fortress against the rest of the world.

To a child like Giovanni, the world was a collection of simple, beautiful truths. The river was for washing, the trees were for shade, and money was a rare, magical paper that brought bread to the table and smiles to his mother's face. In those days, he did not know that the world could be a thief. He did not know that a woman's heart could be as cold as a harmattan wind, or that the very soil he walked upon could swallow a dream and offer nothing in return.

But even in the brightest sunshine, the shadows are waiting. They hide in the corners of greed, in the sudden turn of a tide, and in the silence of an inheritance left unprotected.

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This is the story of a treasure lost twice—once in the corridors of the city, and once in the depths of the earth. It is a story of how a boy was stripped of everything until he was forced to realize that the most valuable thing he possessed was the one thing that could not be stolen, buried, or broken.

The sun is setting on the old Apar. Let us walk into the shadows, so that we may truly understand the light.

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Chapter 1: A Peaceful Home Disappear



“Oh no!” He exclaimed, as his face contoured with grief, “I can’t find it! Where is it? Where is my money?”

With eyes filled with tears, rolling down his cheeks, the little man, just 7 years old, ferociously scrambled through the soil as he stood in the hole he has frantically dug in search for his previously hidden treasure, crying incredulously on the cold, damp, and stubbornly silent earth.

Giovanni’s fingers were no longer just skin and bone; they had become tools of desperation, stained dark by the rich, loamy soil of the village field. He didn’t care about the grit under his fingernails or the way his knees ached from hours of kneeling in the dirt. He only cared about the hole.

“It has to be here,” this time, he whispered, his voice trembling like a leaf in a harmattan breeze. “I put it right here. Under the shadow of the iroko limb.”

He scooped another handful of dirt, his heart hammering against his ribs. The suspense was a physical weight, a tightening in his chest that made every breath feel like a struggle. He had checked this spot every day. He had watered it. He had prayed over it. But as he reached the

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bottom of the excavation, his fingers met nothing but the hard, unyielding floor of the clay subsoil.

The hundred-unit note—his treasure, his seed of hope—was gone. “No... no, no, no!” The cry erupted from him, echoing off the distant trees. He looked around wildly. Was someone watching? The elephant grass swayed in the wind, mimicking the sound of a mocking laugh. Had the earth swallowed it, or had a thief waited for the moon to rise to steal his future? The mystery hung in the air, heavy and suffocating.

Giovanni hadn't always known this desperation. He was born into the warm embrace of Miriam, a mother whose skin smelled of woodsmoke and spices. She was a woman of lean frame but massive spirit—a trader who turned pennies into possibilities and always had a spare coin for a neighbor in need. She had spent Giovanni's first four years weaving a safety net of values around him: industry, empathy, and a quiet, watchful intelligence.

In the city of Loapon, the little man's life had been defined by the smell of fresh-baked bread and the steady, comforting presence of his mother, Miriam. Their home was a sanctuary of order and love. Miriam was a woman of quiet power, a market leader who could settle a dispute between ten traders with a single look.

“Giovvy,” she would say, as he helped her sort dried fish for the morning market. “A man is like a tree. If his roots are in good soil, he will withstand any storm. But if he

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forgets where he came from, the first wind will blow him away.”

His father, Ma'mud, was the wind in their sails. A slender, hardworking man who traveled the coastal routes, he always returned with pockets full of treats and stories of the great ocean.



“Listen to me, Nanna,” she would say, using her pet name for him as they sat in the kitchen. The smell of roasting peppers and fermented locust beans always filled the air. “Money is like a seed. If you treat it with respect, it feeds you. If you waste it, you starve. But a good heart? That is the soil. Without good soil, nothing grows.”

Giovanni was her shadow. He was an inquisitive child, always tugging at her wrapper to ask why the moon followed them or why the beggar at the gate looked so sad. Miriam never brushed him off. She taught him to wash his own clothes, to sweep the compound until the dirt looked like polished glass, and to always say “Thank you” when an elder corrected him.

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Their home was a sanctuary. His father, Ma'mud, was a man of quiet strength who worked as a merchant. When he returned from long trips, the house erupted in joy. Together, they were a perfect triangle, and like a three-cord strand, they were unbreakable—until the day the thread snapped.

Giovanni had lived in the warmth of their protection, never imagining that a shadow could be long enough to reach him. But death is a thief that doesn't negotiate.

The change began with a cough. It started as a small thing, a tickle in Miriam's throat that she brushed off with a laugh. But within weeks, Miriam's brief illness hit like a tidal wave. In the span of a single moon, the vibrant woman who ran the market was replaced by a pale ghost in a bed. Giovanni stayed by her side, trying to read to her from his schoolbooks, just to pull her back into herself. As her strength evaporates, like mist and she drew last breath, the silence in the house was deafening.

When Miriam died, the sun seemed to set on their home. At four years old, Giovanni felt the loss like a physical weight on his chest. He missed the way her hands felt—rough from work but soft in their touch. He missed her voice singing him to sleep.

Ma'mud was a man destroyed. Grief turned his sturdy frame into a skeleton of his former self. He looked at the house and saw only ghosts. He was a man of simple needs and a trusting heart—perhaps too trusting. Ma'mud, paralyzed by his own grief, tried to be both mother and

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father, at the same time, to be the mountain and the meadow for his son. But the grief was a heavy rucksack he couldn't carry alone.

The neighbors in the city of Lapon tried to help at first. Mrs. Ade, the gossiping

but kind bread seller, would bring loaves of hot *agege bread*. "Ma'mud, the boy needs a woman's touch," she would whisper loudly enough for Giovanni to hear. "A house without a woman is just a building." Ma'mud listened. In his desperation to fix a broken home, he made the gravest mistake of his life.

Desperate to give Giovanni a "mother" and himself a partner, Ma'mud's eyes landed on Aisha. She was the physical opposite of the late Miriam—heavy-set, dark-toned, and possessing a gravity that pulled everything toward her own needs. She possesses a voice that could shatter glass. Ma'mud saw her size as a sign of health and prosperity, a contrast to the skinny, hardworking Miriam.

Ma'mud was enchanted by her presence, failing to look beneath the surface. He didn't see the history of a woman spoiled into rot by her own parents, a woman who viewed the world as a servant to her.

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He was a brown tone man with slender stature and stood a height of about 1.1 above the ground. Also, Ma'mud was a permissive man who loved his child. Lately, he has become busily occupied with his business. As a Marchant, he travels a lot. Previously, he met his late wife, Miriam on one of his business trips, carefully studied her, loved her and they got married. However, this time, he was too busy to make background checks on Aisha. He just fell in love with her.

Ma'mud, considered her heavy physique, and gave less concern to Aisha's true character and attitude toward others. He forgot to consider her ability to be a good wife and mother to his dear son. He felt he would love her more since she was the opposite of his late wife in size. Indeed, she was really the exact opposite of Miriam in many ways. Aisha was not just fat; she was also lazy and wicked. He didn't know she was the "spoiled princess" of Tinay'bu village, a woman who had been kicked out of every school for fighting and extortion.

Aisha was the third of four children. Her parent, the natives of the village of Tinay'bu, would do everything she requested just to please her. She would disrespect her elder brothers, cause troubles at school and was known for fighting. She extorts younger children off their properties. Aisha's parents visited the school so many times as they were summoned by the school head for Aisha's troubles.

Her problem was so much that she attended almost all the schools available in their village. Since she became

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notorious in their village, no school would want to admit her. So, she was rejected by those schools who have heard about her and her parents. Yet, her parents think the schools were the problems.

Growing up, Aisha often maltreats her younger brother and regularly fight with her elder brothers for refusing to do her bidding. Her parents pampered her as the only girl, calling her princess and would spoil her with gifts, at the neglect of her other siblings. If she requests for something they do not have, Aisha's parent would go borrowing just to get what she has demanded. In their thinking, they were doing her a favor as the only daughter. What they failed to realize was that they were helping her to become a big, arrogant and lazy fool.

Aisha attracted friends who used fowl languages and would freely use vulgar words. The aura around her was unpleasant. Like birds of a feather, her friends were of like minds. Aisha successfully evaded all the huddles to make her agile and responsible. She eats frequently and would greedily extort other children's food, threatening them of beating, should they resist. Whenever words of her misconducts get to her parents, they would plead, even offer money to the aggrieved just to end the case.

With that mindset, Aisha grew to become a pill of lazy big for nothing beast of a woman who fancy herself a goddess, born to be served. She was satisfied just to eat, have fun and sleep. Working was not her thing as she felt others were supposed to serve her. Her parents were afraid to

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correct her, ‘for fear, they may end up offending their only daughter’. So, they would ignore her, saying: “Leave her alone, she is just a kid. She would change when she grows up.”

Aisha did not enter their lives; she invaded them. The day Aisha moved in; the peace didn't just leave—it fled. She arrived with three trunks of clothes and a heart full of malice. Giovanni remembered her first words to him when his father was out of earshot. She had looked down at the small boy with eyes like cold stones.

“Don't think you're special, little rat,” she hissed, her breath smelling of sour milk. “This is my house now.”

She was a woman of immense voice that sounded like grinding stones. To Ma'mud, her size represented the vitality he had lost. He didn't see the cruelty behind her eyes or the greed in her smile.

“I will take care of the boy, Abraham,” she had promised, her voice dripping with a sweetness that Giovanni instantly mistrusted.

As the weeks turned into months, the beautiful home Miriam had built began to crumble. Aisha refused to cook, demanding Ma'mud buy expensive street food. She screamed at the neighbors, played music so loud the walls vibrated, and treated Giovanni like a stray dog.

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Aisha moved in with lots of her personal opinions. She didn't like the way Miriam had arranged the furniture; she threw out things she did not like. She didn't like the neighbors who came to check on Giovanni; she insulted them until they stopped calling.

Ma'mud, once a proud merchant, began to shrink. He lost weight as Aisha grew larger. His business started to fail because Aisha would insult his customers, calling the women harlots and the men thieves.

Giovanni watched it all. He retreated into himself, finding solace only in the small chores his mother had taught him. He would sweep the floors in silence, tears dripping onto the broom, wondering where the woman went who used to tell him that he was a priceless treasure.

One afternoon, Giovanni found her sorting and wearing his mother's jewelries, her favorite gold earrings.

"Those belong to my mother," Giovanni said, his voice small but firm.

Aisha turned, her face contorting into a mask of rage. She stood up, her massive shadow falling over him. "Your mother is dead, you little rat. Everything in this house

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belongs to me now. If I hear you mention her name again, I will give you a reason to cry that has nothing to do with grief.” She grabbed his ear, twisting it until he fell to his knees. “From now on, you don't speak unless I tell you to. You don't eat unless I leave something on the plate. Do you understand?” Giovanni nodded, hot tears stinging his eyes.

Ma'mud tried to intervene at first, but Aisha's outbursts were volcanic. She would scream for hours, throwing plates and accusing Ma'mud of still loving a dead woman more than a living one. She spent his savings on expensive lace and heavy jewelry, while Giovanni's school uniforms grew tattered and small.

The villagers in the nearby compounds began to talk. Mrs. Ade, the bread seller, would whisper to the other women as Giovanni passed by. “Look at the boy. He is fading. That woman is eating the soul of that house.” But no one stepped in. In the city, doors stayed closed.

As the months passed, the laughter in the house was replaced by the sound of Aisha's demands and the quiet sobbing of a boy who had learned to hide in the corners. Giovanni realized that his mother's "good soil" had been paved over by the concrete of Aisha's malice.

He didn't know that the worst was yet to come. He didn't know that soon, he would be forced to leave the city entirely, and that the "Lost Treasure" of his inheritance was already being gambled away by the woman who called herself his mother.

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Back in the field, the sun finally disappeared, leaving Giovanni in total darkness. He stood up from the empty hole, his knees shaking. The treasure was gone. His father was gone. His mother was a memory.

“I will find out,” he whispered to the night sky, his eyes hardening with a new, dangerous resolve. “I will find out who took it.”

The suspense of the empty hole wasn't just about money anymore; it was about the beginning of a war.

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Chapter 2: The Struggle for Survival



The air in the house at LoPON grew thick with a tension that Giovanni felt in his very bones. It was no longer a home; it was a battlefield where only one side was armed. Aisha had fully transformed from a "new mother" into a domestic tyrant. The vibrant, smiling Giovanni began to fade. The transition was a slow-motion. Her presence expanding to fill every room while Giovanni and his father seemed to shrink.

"Giovanni! Why is the kettle not whistling yet? Do you want me to die of thirst?" Aisha's voice boomed from the bedroom, a sound like rolling thunder that made the boy jump so hard he nearly dropped the matches. "I'm coming, Ma! The firewood was damp from the rain," Giovanni replied, his small voice trembling.

Aisha was a shadow that never lifted. While Ma'mud worked himself to the bone, Aisha slept until noon, waking only to blast music that drowned out the neighborhood's peace or to feast on expensive street food while Giovanni nibbled on scraps.

He was only seven, yet his mornings began at 5:00 AM, long before the sun had cleared the city's smog. While his father, Ma'mud, was out in the streets trying to salvage his dwindling trade business, Giovanni was a servant to

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Aisha's every whim. The kitchen, once Miriam's pride, was now a chaotic mess of grease and unwashed plates. Aisha refused to touch a dish, claiming her "soft city hands" weren't made for such toil.

She spent her days draped across the sofa, her massive frame taking up almost all the space, shouting at the television or barking orders. Giovanni worked in a blur of motion—sweeping, scrubbing, and running to the market for the specific spicy peppers she craved. He had become a master of invisibility, learning exactly which floorboards creaked so he wouldn't wake her during her frequent, snoring afternoon naps.

But the real struggle wasn't just the labor; it was the hunger. Aisha had developed a cruel habit of "forgetting" to feed him. She would buy succulent



pieces of fried chicken and spicy jollof rice from the street vendors, eating greedily while Giovanni sat in the corner with a crust of dry bread and a cup of watery tea.

"You're getting too fat anyway," she would sneer, her eyes tracking his protruding ribs. "A boy needs to stay light if he's going to work."

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Ma'mud was becoming a ghost in his own house. The stress of Aisha's spending and the loss of his trade routes had carved deep lines into his face. He saw the bruises on Giovanni's arms—small pinches and marks where Aisha had "corrected" him—but every time he tried to confront her, a hurricane erupted. Aisha would scream, throw plates, and threaten to leave, knowing Ma'mud was too broken by Miriam's death to handle another loss.

"We cannot stay here, Giovy," Ma'mud whispered one night, huddling with his son in the small room they shared. The city of Lupon had become a place of shame. The debts were piling up, and the neighbors looked at them with pity that stung worse than Aisha's insults. "We will go back to the village. To Apar. There, the land will feed us. There, the waters will help me find peace."

Giovanni nodded, his eyes bright with a desperate hope. He remembered Apar from his early childhood—the wide-open fields, the scent of the river, and the kindness of his father's old friend, Mr. Bola. Maybe in the village, Aisha would change. Maybe the fresh air would wash away her bitterness.

The relocation was a chaotic affair. Aisha objected with a fury that lasted three days, but for the first time, Ma'mud stood his ground. He was bankrupt; there was no choice. They loaded their meager belongings onto a rusted truck, the engine groaning under the weight of Aisha's heavy trunks filled with lace, wigs, and jars of skin-lightening creams.

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The journey to Apar took hours. As the skyscrapers of Lupon were replaced by the emerald green of the rainforest and the red dust of the interior, Giovanni felt a weight lifting. But Aisha sat in the back of the truck, her face a mask of pure hatred. To her, the village was a prison. She was a woman who lived for the vanity of the city. The life of the village felt like a personal insult.

When they arrived at the family compound in Apar, the neighbors gathered to welcome them. Mr. Bola was there, his face warming when he saw Giovanni.

"The little lion has returned!" Bola laughed, reaching out to ruffle Giovanni's hair. But his smile faltered when he saw Aisha stepping down from the truck. The villagers were intuitive; they saw the way she looked at the mud-walled houses with disgust. They felt the coldness she radiated.

"Ma'mud," Mr. Bola pulled him aside later that evening under the moonlight. "The water in your well looks troubled. Who is this woman you have brought to our soil? She does not look like she knows how to plant or harvest."

"She is my wife, Bola. She just... she needs time to adjust," Ma'mud replied, his voice lacking any conviction.

Adjustment, however, was not in Aisha's vocabulary. In the village, everyone worked. The women were in the farms by sunrise or at the riverbanks processing fish. Aisha refused. She sat in front of the house in her city lace,

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demanding the village girls fetch her water. When Ma'mud suggested she help with the planting to save money on food, she laughed in his face.

"I am a city woman! I do not dig in the dirt like a peasant!"

The struggle for survival had moved from the city to the bush, but the predator remained the same. Giovanni, the industrious boy Miriam had raised, took to the village life with a frantic energy. He helped the elders, he fetched water from the stream for the neighbors, and he tried to shield his father from Aisha's escalating rants.

But the shadows were lengthening. Ma'mud was spending more time at sea, fishing deep into the night just to escape the noise of the house. He was exhausted, depressed, and increasingly reckless.

One afternoon, as the sun hung like a heavy gold coin in the sky, Giovanni sat by the riverbank, watching as Mr. Bola's boat disappear into the horizon. He didn't know that a black car was even then winding its way toward their village, carrying a secret that would make him the richest boy in the region—and the most hunted.

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Chapter 3: The Wicked Stepmother



The red dust of Apar usually settled by midday, but the arrival of the sleek, black sedan stirred up more than just dirt; it stirred the curiosity of the entire village. A black sedan pulled up to their rural village home in Apar, where they had retreated after Aisha's toxicity blew up Ma'mud's city business. Out stepped a lawyer, Barrister George Brown. Giovanni stood by the compound gate, his hand shielding his eyes as two figures emerged from the air-conditioned interior. A man in a sharp charcoal suit and a woman carrying a leather briefcase looked like aliens in this land of thatch and clay.

"We are looking for Abraham Ma'mud," the man stated, his voice carrying the clipped authority of the city.

Giovanni led them to his father, who was resting under the shade of a massive baobab tree. But Giovanni wasn't the only one watching. From behind the tattered curtain of the main house, Aisha's dark, greedy eyes were fixed on the briefcase.

The man introduced himself as Barrister George Brown. He asked to speak with Ma'mud in private, but in a village compound, "private" was a relative term. As they walked toward the edge of the clearing, Aisha crept through the

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tall grass, her heavy breathing masked by the rustle of the wind.

"Mr. Ma'mud," the Barrister began, "your late wife, Miriam, was a woman of extraordinary foresight. Seven years ago, she invested a significant sum into



a land-development conglomerate. That investment has matured. You are the sole beneficiary of her estate, which is currently valued at several million dollars." Aisha watched from the bushes as she had trailed them, her eyes narrowing like a cat's, overhearing the impossible truth: Miriam, the "skinny trader," had been a secret visionary.

Ma'mud gasped, his hand flying to his chest. He stumbled back, his eyes filling with tears. "Miriam... she did this for us?"

"Yes, she did," the lawyer replied, opening the briefcase to reveal stacks of legal papers and a thick bundle of cash—the initial 20% payout. "This cash is for your immediate needs. The rest is tied to property and equity. You are, quite literally, a millionaire."

Ma'mud's face cracked into a sob of joy. "Miriam... thank you," he whispered to the wind. He signed the papers,

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clutching the initial 20% cash payout—a literal fortune—as a promise to secure Giovanni's future.

Aisha, huddled in the grass, felt her heart hammer against her ribs. Millionaire. The word tasted like honey in her mouth. She didn't think of the love Miriam had for her son; she thought of the gold she could now drape over her own neck.

The lawyers left as quickly as they had come, leaving Ma'mud in a daze of joy. He clutched the money to his chest, laughing and crying simultaneously. "Giovanni! Giovy, come here!" he shouted. He swung his son into the air; the first time Giovanni had felt his father's strength in months. "We are going back to the city! A new life, my son! No more hunger!"

But the joy was a fragile glass that Aisha was ready to shatter. That evening, she was uncharacteristically kind. She cooked a meal—real pounded yam and '*egusi soup*'—and spoke softly to Ma'mud. She watched where he hid the briefcase under the floorboards of their hut.

"You should go to the sea one last time, Abraham," she whispered that night, her hand resting on his shoulder like a predator's claw. "Give thanks to the waters that fed us when we were poor. Say goodbye to the old life."

Ma'mud, blinded by his newfound fortune and the sudden "warmth" of his wife, agreed. He needed the silence of the ocean to process his change in their new status.

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The next morning, the sky was a bruised purple, a warning that the experienced fishermen of Apar knew well. "The sea is restless today, Ma'mud," Mr. Bola warned as they stood on the shore. "Wait until the tides calm."

"I know my way around the sea, Bola! I'll be back before the first rain," Ma'mud shouted over his shoulder, pushing his narrow canoe into the surf.

Giovanni watched from the beach until the boat was a mere speck on the horizon. He waited all afternoon. He waited through the evening as the purple sky turned into a violent black, and the wind began to howl like a banshee.

The storm that hit Apar that night was legendary. Trees were uprooted, and the waves rose like hungry giants. By morning, the beach was littered with debris, but Ma'mud's boat was not among the wreckage. Days passed. The village men organized search parties, their lanterns bobbing like fireflies along the coast. Mr. Bola returned on the third day, his head bowed. He walked straight to Giovanni and knelt in the sand.

"The sea has kept him, Giovy," he said, his voice thick with grief. "We found the oars... but your father is gone."

Giovanni didn't scream this time. The shock was too deep. He felt as though he were floating outside his own body. He looked toward the house, expecting to see Aisha mourning. Instead, he saw her through the window. She wasn't crying. She was holding the briefcase, a look of

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triumphant victory on her face. The sea kept the man; Aisha kept the money.

The "New Mother" was gone. In her place stood a woman who had exactly what she wanted: the money, the documents, and a child she could finally discard. With Ma'mud gone, the mask slipped entirely. Aisha didn't grieve; she scrambled. She snatched the legal documents and the stacks of cash.

"Pack your things, rat," she barked as soon as the village elders left the compound. "We aren't staying in this hole a second longer."

She didn't tell the villagers where they were going. Under the cover of darkness, she hailed a taxi, piled her trunks into the trunk, and dragged Giovanni into the backseat. As the car sped away from the only people who loved him, Giovanni looked back at the receding lights of Apar. He was a millionaire's son, but he had never felt more like a slave.

For months, Giovanni lived in a nightmare. He was no longer a son; he was a ghost. He washed Aisha's clothes, scrubbed her floors, and flushed her waste, all while his ribs began to poke through his skin like the hull of a wrecked ship. Aisha looked at him with a loathing that bordered on lethal. To her, he wasn't a child; he was the last obstacle between her and total ownership of the Ma'mud fortune.

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The return to the city was not a return to their old life. Aisha, paranoid that the lawyers or the village elders might come looking for the boy's inheritance, did not return to their previous neighborhood. Instead, she rented a cramped, humid apartment where no one asked questions.

For Giovanni, the months that followed were a descent into a private purgatory. Aisha had become a woman of luxury—her hair was always done in intricate braids adorned with gold beads, and her skin smelled of expensive, cloying perfumes. She spent the inheritance as if it were a bottomless well, yet Giovanni was forced to live like a stray. He was the "houseboy" who wasn't allowed to leave the gates. He scrubbed the floors until his knees bled, washed Aisha's massive silk wrappers by hand, and lived on the remnants of her oversized meals.

"You are lucky I didn't leave you in the bush to starve," she would say, kicking his cleaning bucket over just to watch him scramble to dry the floor. "You owe me your life." But the city became too hot for Aisha. Neighbors began to whisper about the source of her wealth and the pale, gaunt boy who lived like a prisoner in her flat.

Fearing a police inquiry or a visit from the tax authorities, Aisha made a cold, calculated decision. She would return to the village—not to live, but to dump the "baggage" that was Giovanni.

On a humid Wednesday, she found him shivering on the floor, weak from three days of fasting. Her voice suddenly

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turned to honey—a sound more terrifying than her scream.

"Eat, Giovanni. We're going on a trip. A better place."

The next morning, they were in a taxi. Giovanni watched the landmarks blur past. He saw the "Lion King" rock and the twin-branched palm tree his father used to point out. His heart hammered against his chest. We're going back to the village.

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Chapter 4: A Treasured Gift



The journey back to Apar was a blur of terror for the boy. When the taxi reached the village square, the taxi screeched to a halt. Before the car could fully stop, and the dust could even settle, Aisha lunged. She grabbed Giovanni's thin arm, twisting it as she dragged him from the seat and flung him, onto the jagged dusty road.

"Go back to the dirt you came from!" she shrieked. The taxi sped off, the tires screamed, kicking up a blinding shroud of grit as the car vanished. Giovanni scrambled up, left alone in the square, his belongings still in the trunk, as he watched the disappearing taxi in a cloud of exhaust. Onlookers were beat up with silence. It was as if they were frozen in time as they all watched the fast-paced scene that had just happened.

Hours later, the villagers who knew his compound found him huddled in the shade of a market stall. Mr. Bola and Mrs. Latif, a kind woman who remembered Miriam's old favors, took him in. But Giovanni was a shell of himself. He sat on the porch of the communal house, staring at nothing, his spirit crushed by the realization that he was truly alone. He fell, his strength spent, his vision blurring into a grey haze as the silence of the village swallowed his cries.

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A week later, a change came in the form of a white woman with a camera and a heavy leather satchel. She was a public health researcher, part of a team studying the local water system. As she struggled up the hilly path toward the village head's house, her bags slipped. Giovanni, moved by the industrious spirit his mother had instilled in him, didn't hesitate. He ran to her side.

"Let me help, Ma," he said, his voice rusty from disuse. He grabbed the heavier bag, straining his small muscles to lift it.

The woman, whose name was Dr. Sarah, was struck by the boy's intensity. Most children in the village would have asked for candy or money first, but this boy just worked. When they reached her destination, she stopped and looked into his bright eyes, seeing the depths of the sadness hidden there.

"You have a very kind heart, young man," she said. She reached into her pocket and pulled out a crisp, new note. It was a 100-unit bill — more money than Giovanni had ever held in his own hands. "This is for your schoolbooks. Thank you."



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Giovanni stared at the note. The bold "100" seemed to glow. To a boy who had lost a million-dollar inheritance, this single bill felt more valuable than all the gold in Aisha's jewelry box. It was the first thing that was truly his.

He ran back to Mrs. Latif's house, his heart pounding. "Look! Look what I have!" Mrs. Latif smiled, but she warned him, "Money is a heavy thing, Giovanni. Be careful where you keep it. In this world, things that are seen are easily taken."

Giovanni nodded, but a strange, naive idea began to sprout in his mind. He remembered his mother talking about "investments." He remembered his father saying money "grows in the bank." He had seen the farmers plant tiny seeds that grew into massive yams. He had seen the rains turn a dry patch into a lush forest.

If money was a seed, as his mother had said, then surely it could grow. In his deep thoughts, Aisha interrupted. She had just returned from the city for unknown reasons just to stay in the village. She help to clear up any remaining treasure she could lay hand hands on before she would say goodbye to village.

Giovanni gave her the house key, but spent more time at Mr. Bola or Mrs. Latif's place, there, he could find the peace of mind he craves for.

He waited until the sunset and the village was silent. He walked to the edge of the field, near the old big tree where

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his father used to rest. He didn't give attention if there could be a pair of hungry eyes watching the entire thing from the shadows.

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Chapter 5: The Planting

The moon over Apar was a silver sickle, cutting through the heavy tropical heat. Giovanni knelt beneath the ancient iroko tree, his small heart drumming a rhythm of desperate hope against his ribs. In his hand, he clutched the 100-unit note Dr. Sarah had given him. To the world, it was just paper; to Giovanni, it was a holy relic, a seed of light in a world that had gone dark.

He began to dig. He didn't use a tool; he wanted his bare skin to touch the earth, to communicate his need to the soil. He dug a small, neat hole in the moist earth. "Grow for me," he whispered, placing the note into the dark soil. "Grow so I can find my Papa. Grow so I can be free."

He covered the note, patting the earth flat with his palms until it looked as though nothing had been disturbed. As he buried the note, his mind drifted back to the stories his



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mother, Miriam, used to talk about "The Great Harvest." But as he smoothed the dirt, a colder memory chilled his blood—the memory of the woman who had made this burial necessary.

Aisha had not been born a monster; she had been crafted into one by a toxic cocktail of neglect and indulgence. Growing up in the chaotic outskirts of the city, she was the only female child of a merchant who had struck it rich late in life and sought to buy his daughter's love rather than earn it. She was a "spoilt brat" in the truest sense of the word. While other children were taught the discipline of the hearth and the value of a hard day's labor, Aisha was taught that the world was a vending machine.

Her upbringing lacked the iron rod of discipline. When she threw tantrums, she was rewarded with sweets. When she failed her lessons, her father blamed the teachers. She grew up with a bloated ego and a hollow soul, believing that physical beauty and loud demands were the only currencies that mattered. But when her father's business collapsed and he died in debt, Aisha was left with the tastes of a queen and the skills of a beggar. She hadn't been taught how to create wealth—only how to consume it.

This lack of discipline turned into a predatory instinct. She looked for men like Ma'mud—kind, grieving, and stable—and moved in like a parasite. To Aisha, Giovanni wasn't a child; he was a rival for resources. She hated him because he represented the "good soil" of Miriam's discipline, a discipline she had never known.

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Back in the present, Giovanni patted the earth flat. He placed a secret stone on top of the mound, unaware that Aisha was watching from the window of the nearby hut. She didn't see a boy planting a dream; she saw a "stubborn rat" playing in the mud, her obstacle to all her belongings. In her mind, anything Giovanni possessed was a personal insult to her own luxury.

"Grow," Giovanni whispered to the dark earth. "Grow so I can find my way home."

He stood up and walked back to Mrs. Latif's house, his spirit light. But the silence of the field was a lie. As soon as his footsteps faded, the tall grass near the iroko tree parted. A heavy figure stepped into the moonlight. It was the neighbor, a man who had often been the target of Aisha's manipulations, but tonight, he was acting on his own. He had seen the "spoilt woman" watching the boy, and he decided to investigate what was trendy.

The suspense of the coming days began to thicken like the humidity before a storm. Giovanni went to bed dreaming of a tree with leaves made of silver, while in the shadows, a betrayal was already growing.

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Chapter 6: Assured Hope

The days following the planting were the most beautiful of Giovanni's life, fueled by a delusion so powerful it felt like truth. He moved through the village of Apar with the quiet confidence of a prince in disguise. Every morning at dawn, before the first cock crowed, he was at the iroko tree with a gourd of water, carefully pouring it over the spot where his treasure lay. He talked to the ground, telling it stories of his mother's market days and his father's fishing trips.

"I will be the richest boy in Apar," he told the earth. "And I will build a school for everyone."

Days turned into a week. Every morning, he checked the spot. He expected to see a tiny sprout breaking through the crust of the earth. He imagined branches made of silver and leaves made of gold. He reasoned that if a tiny maize seed could produce a stalk taller than a man in weeks, then surely a hundred-unit note—something so much more "powerful"—would yield a harvest that would stagger the village.

This was his "Assured Hope." It was a fortress he built in his mind to keep out the reality of his father's death and Aisha's looming presence. He was so consumed by his fantasy that he didn't notice the way some of the village

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boys whispered when he passed, or the way the dirt around his hole looked slightly looser than he had left it.

His hope was so strong that it became his armor. When the older boys teased

him for being the "city boy who lost his shoes," he didn't cry. He simply smiled a secret, knowing smile.

Giovanni decided to make plans for his future. He sat beneath the shade of a nearby tree, took out a stick, and began to write in the dirt. He planned what he would do with the "Money Tree."

He began to act out his future. He would sit by the river and practice his "millionaire's walk," imagining himself returning to the city to buy back his father's house. Giovanni exclaimed, his eyes shining with excitement.

"I'll buy a grand house; help many poor people and I will never go hungry again!" He drew maps of a grand house with a roof made of slate that wouldn't leak. He drew a school with rows of desks where every child in Apar could sit and learn to read the big words in the lawyers' books.

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“When I finish building the school for the children then I will build a house for Mrs. Latif.”

He even began to forgive Aisha in his heart, thinking, when my tree grows, I will give her enough money to go away forever. I will buy my peace.

But hope without discipline is a dangerous thing. While Giovanni was lost in his dreams, the reality of the village was closing in. Aisha was becoming restless. She had spent greater percentage of the cash she had stolen from the briefcase, and her "spoilt brat" nature was turning into a violent desperation. She began to sell off the village compound's goats—animals that didn't even belong to her—to fund her cravings for city gin and expensive lace.

"Where is the boy getting his strength?" Aisha muttered to herself, watching Giovanni from afar. She saw his glowing face and his energetic stride. To a woman who only found joy in taking, seeing someone find joy in waiting was a mystery she intended to solve.

She began to follow him. She watched him water the ground. She saw the way he whispered to the dirt. Her lack of upbringing had left her superstitious and fearful; she began to believe the boy was practicing some kind of "child-magic" to bring back his father's ghost. The tension in the house reached a breaking point. One night, she grabbed Giovanni by the throat, her breath smelling of fermented corn.

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"What are you doing in that field, you little wizard?" she hissed. "If I find out you're working against me, I'll bury you in the same dirt you're so fond of!"

Giovanni didn't flinch. His hope was his armor. "It's a secret for the family, Ma," he said, using the title that tasted like ash in his mouth. "A secret that will make us all rich."

As the days passed, Giovanni continue to tend to his money tree with care. He watered it, sang to it, and even told it stories. He was convinced that with love and attention, it would grow into the most magnificent tree in the land.

Aisha let him go, her eyes narrowing. She didn't believe in family; she only believed in the "now." The assured hope of the boy and the predatory greed of the woman were on a collision course, and the crash would happen at the roots of the iroko tree.

Despite the crushing silence of the delay in growth, a strange, resilient part of Giovanni refused to let the dream die. He began to obsess over the phrase his mother used to murmur: "Good things take time to root."

He convinced himself that perhaps he hadn't waited long enough. He started to spend his evenings by the village stream, watching the way the water smoothed the stones. He watched how a fallen seed from a mahogany tree would sit in the dry brush for weeks, seemingly dead, only to explode into life after a single heavy downpour.

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"It is still there," he would whisper to himself, clutching his knees. "It is just building its strength. It is turning into a forest."

He even found a small stick and began to mark the days on the bark of a baobab tree. Ten days. Fourteen days. Twenty days. He was assured. He was certain. The universe could not be so cruel as to take his mother, his father, and his last treasure. There had to be a balance. There had to be a harvest.

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Chapter 7: Crushed Hope

The morning of the third week arrived on a Tuesday, with a sky the color of a bruised plum. Giovanni had not slept. The "Assured Hope" that had carried him through the last twenty-one days had reached a fever pitch. In his mind, the hundred-unit note had already multiplied, its paper roots turning into a subterranean treasure chest. He stole away from Mrs. Latif's house while the morning mist was still thick enough to hide his silhouette. The air was thick and humid; the kind of weather that made the dragonflies hover low over the grass.

As he reached the big iroko tree, he felt a sudden, sharp chill. Now he noticed that the secret stone he used to mark the spot was slightly tilted. His heart gave a sickening thud. The wind, he told himself. It was just the wind. He knelt, his knees sinking into the damp red earth, and began to dig with a rusted shovel he had borrowed from Mrs. Latif's shed.

The first few inches were easy. The soil was loose, still moist from his constant watering. But as he reached the depth where the note should have been, his fingers met nothing but cold, unyielding clay. He dug faster, his breathing becoming ragged, a high-pitched whimpering sound escaping his throat.

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He expanded the hole, throwing dirt behind him in a frantic spray.

Nothing.

He dug until the hole was wide enough to bury a small animal.

Nothing.

He dug until his fingernails were torn and his cuticles bled, mixing his own red blood with the red earth of Apar.

Still, nothing.

This time, he didn't just dig a small hole. He excavated the entire area. He frantically worked until began gasping for air. He refused to accept the dark reality that the money is gone. He continued searching until the sun began to dip below the horizon, painting the sky in shades of blood-orange and bruised purple. The little man dug until he hit the hard, unyielding clay beneath the topsoil.

“No! It’s gone! It’s gone!”

The scream that tore from Giovanni’s throat didn't sound like a seven-year-old boy; it sounded like a wounded animal. His small, trembling hands were caked in mud, the dirt wedged deep under his fingernails as he frantically scooped handfuls of earth out of the hole. He was standing in a self-made crater in the middle of a secluded patch of

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the village field, his chest heaving. Just days ago, this spot had been a sanctuary of hope. Now, it was a grave.

"It has to be here," he gasped, his voice breaking. "God doesn't lie. The earth doesn't steal." He cried profusely and

But the earth was empty. The hundred-unit note—the seed



of his entire future—was gone. The realization didn't hit him all at once; it came in waves of crushing weight. First came the denial, the idea that he had simply forgotten the exact spot. Then came the terror, the knowledge that he was now truly penniless. Finally, there was the crushing weight of his loss. He realized that while he had been dreaming of sunshine, the darkness had been busy.

"Where is it?" he sobbed, his voice cracking. He dropped to his knees, ignoring the sharp stones cutting into his skin. He had buried his treasure so carefully. He had smoothed the earth. He had waited. But as he reached the bottom of the pit, there was nothing but damp, cold soil. No crisp note. No glimmer of wealth. Just an empty, mocking void.

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The realization hit him with the force of a physical blow. The money was gone. Truly, permanently gone. Whether it had rotted into the fibers of the earth or been snatched by a thief, the result was the same: Giovanni was penniless. He was the "millionaire's son" who couldn't even afford a bowl of garri.

He collapsed into the hole he had dug, his small body shaking with sobs that seemed to come from his very soul. He threw the shovel into the brush and slumped to the ground. The hope that had sustained him for weeks turned into a bitter poison. He felt a deep, burning shame. He felt like a fool—a child who had believed in fairy tales while the real world was busy chewing him up.

"I am nothing," he sobbed, his face pressed into the very dirt that had betrayed him. "I have nothing."

He saw himself through Aisha's eyes—a "rat" playing in the dirt. The suspense of who had taken it began to claw at him. Was it the neighbor? Was it a passing traveler? Or had Aisha, with her predatory intuition, seen him and taken it just to watch him break? The disappointment was so absolute that he felt he might never stand up again. The iroko tree, which had felt like a guardian, now looked like a silent witness to his humiliation.

A twig snapped in the distance. Giovanni froze, his tear-filled eyes darting toward the thicket of elephant grass. He wet closer to investigate and saw a left foot of a foot wear. It looks like someone had left it in a hurry. Had someone been watching? Was there a pair of eyes hidden in the

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shadows, laughing at his idiocy? Or had the earth itself swallowed his only hope? The suspense hung in the air, heavy and suffocating, like the heat before a tropical storm.

The suspense of the theft—the unanswered question of who or what took it—became a heavy chain around his neck. He looked at the surrounding trees, and for the first time, they didn't look like guardians; they looked like witnesses. He felt small, unprotected, and utterly defeated. The sunshine he had tried so hard to find had been eclipsed by a shadow darker than any he had known before.

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Chapter 8: The Disappointment



Giovanni remained by the hole for hours, even as the village began to wake and the sounds of daily life echoed through the trees. He was a boy draped in a shroud of disappointment. When he finally crawled out of the dirt and shuffled back toward the village, he didn't look like a child anymore. His eyes were hollow, reflecting a world that had promised a miracle and delivered a void.

He sat on the edge of the communal porch, staring at his filthy, bleeding hands as it rained slightly. Mrs. Latif came to his first aid and attended to his injuries, while she tried to console him of his experience and took him to her house. Since he had refused to eat swallow, she tried to offer him a bowl of pap, but he couldn't eat. The disappointment had stolen his appetite, just as the thief had stolen his note.

The hours following the disappearance of the money were a blur of silent agony. Giovanni moved through the village like a ghost; his mind trapped in a loop of "what ifs." Had a heavy rain washed it deeper into the earth? Had a burrowing animal mistaken the paper for bedding? Or, most painfully, had a person—someone he might walk past every day—watched him in his most vulnerable moment and waited for the moon to rise to steal his future? The footwear was a clue he would have to investigate.

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Mr. Bola, a close neighbor to Mrs. Latif, returned from morning fishing and was briefed. Mr. Bola came to see meet him there. The old fisherman didn't offer a hug or soft words. He waited for the silence to sink in. After a long while, Mr. Bola finally broke the silence.

"I saw you in the field, Giovanni," Bola said quietly, held his hand and took him along with him. "Digging for a paper."

They sat down heavily next to each other and Mr. Bola began to sharpen a fishing hook with a whetstone. The rhythmic shick-shick-shick was the only sound for a long time.

"You are mourning a piece of paper, Giovy," Bola said finally, not looking up from his work.

"It wasn't paper," Giovanni whispered, his voice hoarse from crying. "It was my way out. It was the seed. My mother said money is a seed, and I planted it, and it's gone. The earth is a thief, Papa Bola." I think someone stole it.

Giovanni flinched. "It didn't grow, Papa Bola. I planted it like a seed, but the earth ate it."

Bola stopped sharpening, looked at the boy and then he started to weave his fishing net. This was the moment where the shadows of his intellect met the sunshine of wisdom. "Your mother was a wise woman, but she forgot to tell you one thing. A seed only grows if it is the right kind for the soil. You tried to plant a man-made thing in

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God's earth. That is not faith, Giovy. That is magic. And magic is for people like Aisha—people who want something for nothing. Money is not a seed of the earth. It is a seed of the mind. When people say 'money grows on trees,' they are speaking



in riddles—it is a metaphor." Giovanni looked up, a flicker of light returning to his dull eyes.

"A meta-what?" Giovanni wiped his eyes.

"A metaphor," Bola repeated. "It means that wealth comes from the fruit of your labor and the wisdom in your head. You cannot bury a note and expect a tree, but you can bury a lesson in your heart and expect a future.

"The disappointment you feel today," Bola continued, "is not because you are poor; it is because you looked for your power in the ground instead of in yourself. So, let it be the death of your childhood. You thought the world would give you a tree of gold because you were a good boy? Look, the world doesn't work on 'good.' It works on 'will.' The person who took your money—whether it was the

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wind, a thief, or the devil herself—they only took the paper. They couldn't take the three weeks you spent hoping. They couldn't take the discipline you used to water that ground every morning."

"Your mother was a trader," Bola continued. "She didn't bury her coins. She moved them. she used them to buy, to sell, and to learn. She grew her wealth through the 'trees' of her relationships and her knowledge. Do you understand?"

Giovanni looked at his muddy hands. He thought about the alphabet he had started to learn in Loapon. He thought about the way the white researcher had looked at him—not with pity, but with respect for his work.

Mr. Bola stood up and handed Giovanni the whetstone. "The money is gone, Giovanni," Bola said, "Stop looking at the hole. The hole is for dead things. Let the earth have it. You are alive. It was a small price to pay for the lesson you just learned. If you want to grow a 'money tree,' you have to become the trunk yourself. You have to be the one who stands tall while the wind tries to knock you down. Now, the question is: what will you plant in your head?"

The disappointment didn't vanish; it began to transform. It turned from a hollow ache into a gold. It was no longer a weight that pulled him down; it was a fire that started to burn in his gut. Giovanni looked at his hands—the dirt was still there, but beneath the dirt was the skin of a survivor. His first suspicion of who the theft could be was Aisha. Since she returned back to the village and had

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refused to go back to the city for reasons best known to her, instead she had been so curious to know his source of happiness. Giovanni realized that Aisha had been "spoilt" because she never had to dig a hole and find it empty. She only knew how to take. He, Giovanni, now knew how to lose—and that made him dangerous.

Giovanni stood up and walked to the edge of the porch. He looked out at the village. He didn't have a hundred-unit bill anymore, but he had something Aisha couldn't steal and the earth couldn't rot. He had a resilient will.

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Chapter 9: Resilient Will

The fire of disappointment had burned away the boy who believed in magic, leaving behind a young man of iron. Giovanni no longer looked at the iroko tree with longing; he looked at the village square as a canvas. If the earth would not grow a money tree, it would have to yield a different kind of harvest: knowledge.

Giovanni was twelve now, though his body, hardened by years of meager meals and heavy labor, made him look no older than nine. The childhood roundness of his face had been replaced by sharp, hungry angles, and his eyes had become observant, like those of a hawk.

While the other children in Apar donned their crisp, starch-white uniforms and headed to the community school, Giovanni remained in the dust. Aisha had seen to it that he had no papers, no fees, and no future. But she had underestimated one thing: the boy had the blood of Miriam, and Miriam never accepted a closed door. If he could not go to the school, Giovanni decided, he would bring the school to the earth.

Every morning, before the sun had fully climbed over the horizon, Giovanni would sweep the village square. He did this for free, earning the silent respect of the elders. But the sweeping was only the preparation. Once the ground

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was smooth and the dust was fine, he would take a sharpened mahogany stick and begin his ritual.

Next, Giovanni was at the stream before the first light touched the water. He didn't just fetch water for Mrs. Latif; he waited for the village children who attended the mission school. He would wait at the gate for the "lucky" children to return, bartering chores for information. "Show me what the teacher taught you today?" He would ask. He watched them with their heavy leather bags and their proud, clean uniforms.

For some, he would bribe them with juicy palm kernels or stories he made up about the city, just to hear them recite the alphabet. Among them was Tunde, a boy whose father was wealthy enough to pay fees but whose mind was often too clouded to focus on his lessons.

Then, Giovanni would return to his swept square. With the intensity of a master artist, he would carve the letters into the dirt. A. B. C. He would practice writing them over and over again.

Forbidden from school by his lack of funds, Giovanni turned the village into his classroom. Using the sharpened mahogany stick, he continues to carve the alphabet—A to Z—till they became perfect, giant letters. It was his "Earth School." If anyone dared step on a letter, Giovanni would block their path, his eyes fierce. "You fix it. Rewrite the 'B' or you don't pass." His obsession with knowledge became a village legend.

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This square became his cathedral. He fiercely protected his "classrooms." If a goat wandered near, he chased it away. If a neighbor attempted to walk across his carefully carved vowels, Giovanni would stand in their path, his small chest puffed out.

"You must step around," he would say firmly. "These are my words. If you crush them, you must rewrite them."

Most villagers laughed and walked around, charmed by his spirit. But some grumbled. One afternoon, a drunkard stumbled through the square, scuffing his heavy boots right through the middle of Giovanni's "M" and "N."

Giovanni didn't just cry; he grabbed the man's wrapper. "You have broken my mother's letter! Fix it! Fix it now!"

The man tried to shake him off, but Giovanni held on, wailing with a grief that sounded like it came from the very center of the earth. The villagers gathered, and eventually, the man, shamed by the boy's passion, awkwardly took the stick and traced the letters back into the dust.

Giovanni wasn't just learning to read; he was learning to survive. He began to solve "calculations" in the dirt, counting the bags of cocoa the farmers brought in or the number of fish in the morning catch. His mind was a sponge, soaking up every scrap of knowledge that drifted his way. He proved that a resilient will is more powerful than a locked gate.

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"Tunde," Giovanni called out one afternoon as the boys trudged home. "Your bag looks like a mountain on your back. Give it to me. I will carry it all the way to your father's compound." Tunde looked suspicious. "And what do you want? I have no money for you, Dust-Boy."

Giovanni reached into his pocket and pulled out a handful of roasted palm kernels—sweet, crunchy, and rare. "I don't want money. I want you to open your slate. Show me the squiggles the teacher made today. Tell me the sounds they make, and these kernels are yours."

It became a secret trade. Every day, he became a pack mule for the school children, his small frame straining under the weight of three or four bags at once. As payment, he gets "stolen"



crumbs of education. He learned the alphabet from a girl named Sarah; he learned the multiplication tables from a boy named Chidi.

When the sun went down and the other children went to their warm meals, Giovanni would go to his

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"classroom"—a flat, swept patch of red earth behind Mrs. Latif's hut. Using the mahogany stick, he would recreate everything he had seen. A is for Apple. 2 times 2 is 4. His upbringing with Miriam had given him a discipline that Aisha, the "spoilt brat," could never comprehend.

While Aisha spent her days screaming at neighbors and complaining



about the "primitive" village life, Giovanni was building a palace in the dirt. He wrote until his fingers cramped, and then he wrote some more. He practiced the English he heard the teacher use, repeating the words until they lost their foreign grit and felt smooth in his mouth.

Then came the day of the "Impossible Problem." One evening, he was practicing his long division when a shadow fell across his "slate." It was Tunde, looking distressed.

"The teacher gave us a riddle of numbers," Tunde whispered, showing a slate covered in messy, incorrect calculations. "If I don't solve it by morning, my father will use the cane. He says if I fail again, I will be sent to work

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the cocoa farms." Giovanni, leaning on his left arm, looked at the scribbles. The problem was a practical question about interest and trade—the very things his mother Miriam used to discuss at the kitchen table in the city. He didn't just see numbers; he saw bags of fish and crates of bread.

"Sit," Giovanni commanded. For the next hour, the "Dust-Boy" became the master. He used pebbles to show Tunde how the numbers moved, how they grew and divided. He didn't just give the answer; he gave the understanding. By the time the moon was high, Tunde's slate was a work of art. "You're a genius, Giovanni," Tunde said in awe.

"No," Giovanni replied, looking at his mahogany stick. "I'm just hungry for something that can't be stolen."

He took Tunde's stick and, with lightning speed, mapped out the solution in the dust. The logic was flawless. When Tunde returned to school the next day, the teacher was stunned.

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Chapter 10: The Change

The success of Tunde was the spark that set the village of Apar talking. When Tunde received the highest marks in the mission school for mathematics, the teacher, a stern man named Mr. Oke, was suspicious. He knew Tunde's limits.

"Who helped you with this, Tunde?" Mr. Oke asked, the cane resting on his desk.

"It was the boy in the square, sir. The one who carries our bags," Tunde confessed.

"This is not the work of a student who has only sat in these classrooms. This is the work of a boy who understands the soul of business."

Curiosity brought Mr. Oke to the village square the following Saturday. He expected to find a boy playing in the mud. Instead, he found a scholar. Giovanni was in the middle of a complex geometric drawing, explaining to a group of younger children how the stars could be used to navigate the sea—a practical lesson he had absorbed from his father, Ma'mud, and translated into the language of his "Earth School."

Mr. Oke stood in silence, watching the mahogany stick move with the precision of a scalpel. He saw the map of

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Nigeria drawn in the dust, with every major river and city marked. He saw the logic, the discipline, and the "Resilient Will" that had turned a tragedy into a triumph. Mr. Oke, a man who valued brilliance over birthright, saw the calloused hands and the sharp, intelligent eyes.

"You have no books," Mr. Oke said, stepping into the square.

Giovanni stood up, wiping his dusty hands on his half trousers. "The earth is my book, sir. And the rain is my eraser."

Mr. Oke had seen many children destroyed by the "Aisha's" of the world—the spoilt, the lazy, and the entitled. But in Giovanni, he saw the opposite. He saw a "Lost Treasure" breaking through the shadows.

"You have a gift, Giovanni," Mr. Oke said. "It is a waste to let the rain wash your knowledge away every night."

"There is a scholarship, Giovanni," Mr. Oke continued, his voice thick with emotion. "It is funded by the government for children of 'exceptional promise' who have been denied a formal education. I was going to recommend the Chief's son, but he has never carried a bag in his life. He has never had to dig a hole and find it empty."

Through Mr. Oke's influence and the communal pleading of Mr. Bola and the villagers, Giovanni was offered a full,

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life-changing scholarship to the Lapon Academy—the very city that had once tried to swallow him whole.

The news of the scholarship hit the village like a lightning bolt. When the official letter arrived, bearing the gold seal of the Ministry of Education, Aisha's rage was volcanic. She couldn't understand how the "rat" she had tried to drown in the village had managed to swim to the shore of greatness.



"It's my money!" she screamed, trying to grab the scholarship letter. "I am his mother! If there is a prize, it belongs to me!"

But for the first time, the village stood as one. Mr. Bola, Mrs. Latif, and even the fathers of the children Giovanni had tutored stepped forward.

"He is not yours, Aisha," Mr. Bola said, his voice like a crashing wave. "He belongs to the soil of Apar now. And the soil has decided to let him bloom."

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When the silver jeep arrived to take Giovanni to the prestigious Atlantic Academy in the city, he didn't look at Aisha. He didn't look at the house. He took along his mahogany stick, stuck into his pocket, a reminder of the boy who refused to be buried. He walked to Mr. Bola and thanked him for become a father to him when he lost one. Then he went to Mrs. Latif, embracing her tightly.

"I'll miss you Mama, but I am coming back," he said appreciatively to Mrs. Latif, for her kindness. "I am coming back!"

Giovanni didn't just attend school; he dominated it. Within two years, Giovanni became one of the best students the Academy had ever seen. He didn't just learn; He became the "Dream Child" of every mother in the city, a symbol of what can happen when resilience meets opportunity. He won many trophies, topped every list, and spoke with a wisdom that left adults breathless.

Back in the village, Aisha discovers a mansion from one of the investments of Miriam. So, she moved in to the accommodation in the city. This was a secluded mansion where no one would bother to look. There, she hopes to start life afresh. She got a young lover and they both lived in the accommodation.

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Chapter 11: Hope Renewed

The iron gates of the Atlantic Academy did not just open to allow a young man to leave; they opened to release a legacy. The boy who had written in the dirt was now a young man of eighteen, his shoulders broad and his gaze steady, his eyes carrying the depth of a thousand lifetimes. As he stepped into the waiting car, he felt the weight of the mahogany stick tucked into his leather satchel—the same stick that had been his only pen in the red dust of Apar. Today was not just the day of his graduation; it was the day of his reckoning.

The victory of this moment brought to mind the corpses of the things Giovanni had lost—losses so profound that no amount of gold could ever buy them back. He had lost the warmth of his mother, Miriam, whose laughter had once been the heartbeat of their home. Time could not bring back the scent of her lavender soap or the way her hands felt when she smoothed his hair.

He had lost his father, Ma'mud, a man of quiet strength who had been swallowed by a hungry sea, leaving behind only an empty boat and an aching silence. He had lost his childhood, stripped away by the calloused hands of a woman who viewed a child's joy as a personal affront. He had even lost that hundred-unit note—the "seed" he had buried with such frantic, innocent prayer. These losses

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were priceless treasures to him, when he needed them most. However, they became the casualties of a world that could be as cruel as a winter storm.

As the car wound through the familiar streets of Lopon, Giovanni looked out the window. The city had changed, but the shadows remained. He remembered the first time he was brought back here, years ago, after Ma'mud's death. Aisha had fled the village, terrified that the elders of Apar would see through her mask. She had dragged Giovanni to this city, using him as a domestic slave to maintain her lifestyle. But the city had eyes. Neighbors had whispered about the bruises on the boy's arms; the police had begun to circle the house like vultures sensing a kill. In a fit of "spoilt" cowardice, Aisha had fled back to the village, dumping Giovanni like unwanted baggage. It was that very abandonment that had led him to the "Earth School" and, eventually, to the scholarship that saved him.

While Giovanni was mastering the arts of rhetoric, logic, and law, Aisha had returned to the city one final time. She had moved into Miriam's primary estate—a grand house with white pillars and a garden that had once been Miriam's pride. There, Aisha's lack of upbringing became her undoing. Raised as a "spoilt brat" who believed that beauty was a substitute for character, she lacked the discipline to manage the wealth she had stolen. She lived for the "now," for the glitter of the moment.

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It was in this vacuum of character that she met Jude, a man who was her own dark reflection. Jude was younger, charming, and possessed the same entitled rot that infested Aisha. He was also a drug addict, a man whose hunger for the needle was even greater than Aisha's hunger for gold.

While she thought she had found a lover to share her stolen palace, she had actually invited a parasite. Over the years, Jude systematically dismantled Miriam's estate. He sold the Italian marble, pawned the heirloom jewelry, and finally disappeared into the city's underbelly with the remaining deeds and the last of the cash.

Now, Giovanni stood before that very house. The white pillars were stained, and the garden was a graveyard of weeds. He was accompanied by Barrister George Brown—the same man who had brought the news of the inheritance years ago—and a team of legal authorities. As they walked up the cracked driveway, Aisha emerged from the shadows of the servant's quarters. She was unrecognizable. Her vanity had been eaten away by stress; her skin was sallow, and her eyes were wild with the frantic energy of the desperate.

The woman who stood there was a ghost of the tyrant she once was. Aisha's gold jewelry was gone, replaced by cheap plastic beads. Her skin-lightening creams had left her face blotchy, and the house behind her smelled of stale palm oil and neglect. She had gambled and spent her way through millions, and now, the well was dry.

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"You cannot be here!" she shrieked, her voice a jagged blade of sound. "This is my house! I am the widow! I am the mother!"

Giovanni stopped. He looked at her, and for the first time in his life, he didn't feel fear. He felt a profound, chilling pity. "You are not a mother, Aisha. You are a thief who forgot that the most important things cannot be kept in a briefcase."

The Barrister stepped forward, his voice like a gavel. "Madam, the evidence of your maltreatment, your fraudulent use of trust documents, and your failure to protect the minor's interest has been documented for five years. This property, and all others associated with the estate of Miriam and Ma'mud, are now legally vested in Giovanni. The audit is complete. You have exhausted the liquid assets, but the properties and the land development



company Miriam established were protected by a trust that could only be accessed when Giovanni turned eighteen. You have one hour to remove yourself and any personal effects."

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As the officers moved past her to secure the perimeter, Aisha ran outside and collapsed on the ground, close to a struggling little flower. Her wailing filling the empty courtyard. She cried out about the "injustice," about the lover who had betrayed her, about the "bad luck" that had followed her. She was a woman who had never learned that you reap what you sow. Because she had planted only greed and chaos, she had harvested only ash. By this time, the Barrister, the two officers and Giovanni had approached closer, the Barrister reiterated the decree.

Then, Giovanni walked into the apartment, his footsteps steady. He entered the house and stood in the center of the grand hall. The echoes of his childhood were there, but the grief was gone. He realized that while time could not bring back his parents or his lost money, it had proven something far more valuable.

Aisha had taken the millions, the documents, and the house—yet she had ended up with nothing because she lacked the "internal treasure." She had no discipline, no honesty, and no truth. Her "spoilt" upbringing had left her with a hollow center that collapsed the moment the wind blew.

The obscurities to a restored hope journey were complete. Giovanni was no longer a victim of his history; he was the architect of his future. As he watched the authorities lead a broken Aisha away from the gate, he knew that the greatest revenge wasn't a prison cell—it was living a life so full of light that the darkness had no place to hide.

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With the help of international advocacy groups moved by his story, the legal documents Aisha had hidden were recovered. The remaining inheritance of Miriam and Ma'mud were finally restored to its rightful heir.

For Giovanni, he had been given something Aisha could never understand. Even in the depths of his poverty, he had carried the "Priceless Treasure" Miriam had given him: the treasure of a good upbringing. She had taught him that honesty was a shield, that truth was a compass, and that labor was a prayer.

This was the inheritance that could not be stolen by a stepmother, drowned by the sea, or taken by a drug-addicted lover. It was this internal wealth that had allowed him to carry bags for kernels, to write in the dust, and to rise to the top of the Atlantic Academy.

A week later, Giovanni returned to the village of Apar. He drove a modest car filled with new schoolbooks, slates, and bags of high-quality rice. The villagers gathered, shouting his name. He went straight to the village square, where a group of children were playing. He knelt in the dirt, exactly where his "Money Tree" hole had been. He reached into his pocket and pulled out a hundred-unit note—the same denomination he had lost as a child. He held it up for the children to see.

“Many years ago,” Giovanni told them, his voice carrying across the clearing, “I buried a note like this in this very spot. I thought it would grow into a tree. When it disappeared, I thought I had lost everything.”

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He looked toward the bushes where he believed the thief had once hidden. An old man, a neighbor who had lived in bitterness for years, was his prime suspect. Giovanni didn't point him out. He simply smiled.

“I realized later that the thief didn't steal my money. They stole my laziness. They forced me to grow my own roots.”

Giovanni handed some cash to the village head to be used for the school fund. Then, he took his old mahogany stick—the one he had kept all through his years at the Academy—and handed it to a young, gaunt boy who reminded him of himself.

“The treasure isn't in the hole, Nanna,” He whispered to the boy. “The treasure is the hand that holds the stick.”

As the sun set over Apar, the red dust turned to gold. Giovanni stood by the river, looking out at the horizon where his father's boat had once vanished. For the first time, he didn't feel the weight of the shadows. He felt only the warmth of the sunshine, a light that came not from the sky, but from a will that could never be buried.

Giovanni stood up and looked at the horizon. The memories of his past were finally retreating, replaced by a light that was constant and true. He had lost his parents, his home, and his childhood, but he had found himself. And in the world of men, there is no treasure greater than a resilient soul armed with the truth.

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He returned, not just with gold, but with hope. He didn't build a fence around his wealth. He built a school—one where the alphabet was carved in hearts, so no one could ever step on a child's dream again.

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THE AUTHOR



Ubi Fredrick is a multifaceted literary architect, mentor, and tech enthusiast who believes that the most powerful stories are the ones that give a voice to the silent. With a diverse background that spans the realms of science, technology, and the humanities, Fredrick brings a unique, analytical precision to the art of suspense-driven storytelling.

His literary journey is defined by a commitment to "literary midwifery"—the process of nurturing raw thoughts and hidden dreams into polished, impactful works of art. This is most evident in his collaborative projects, where he serves as a catalyst for emerging voices, guiding them from the shadows of self-doubt into the sunshine of published reality. Fredrick's writing is characterized by deep empathy, atmospheric detail, and a relentless focus on the resilience of the human spirit.

Beyond the written word, Fredrick is a man of service. As a dedicated Sign Language instructor and interpreter, he works at the frontline of communication, bridging the gap for those with hearing disabilities. He is fluent in American Sign Language (ASL), British Sign Language (BSL), and Nigerian Sign Language (NSL), reflecting his belief that every human being deserves to be understood.

A resident of the intersection between logic and creativity, Fredrick views knowledge as a sacred gift that must be shared. Whether he is interpreting for the deaf, exploring the latest in tech, or penning a heart-wrenching scene for a new book, his mission remains the same: to inspire hope and champion the truth.

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A single seed of hope. A mountain of betrayal. A treasure that cannot be buried.

In the bustling city of Lapon, young Giovanni's life is a "perfect triangle" of love, anchored by his protective father and his visionary mother, Miriam. But when the light of his home is extinguished by tragedy, the shadows move in. Her name is Aisha—a woman whose greed is as vast as her cruelty.

Stripped of his inheritance and exiled to the red dust of the village of Apar, Giovanni is left with nothing but a single gift: a hundred-unit note. Driven by a child's naive faith and his mother's whispered wisdom that "money is a seed," he buries his last treasure in the earth, praying for a miracle.

When the hole is found empty, the real journey begins.

The *Lost Treasure* is a gripping tale of resilience set against the vibrant backdrop of Nigeria. It follows a boy's transformation through the "Earth School"—from a broken servant to the "Dust Scholar." As Giovanni learns to write his future in the soil with a mahogany stick, he discovers that while paper can vanish and the sea can claim lives, no one can touch the wealth of a resilient will.

Will Giovanni discover the real truth about his last hope, or will he learn a fortune that the world never saw coming?